

The Other Side of the Wall

They had shared a wall for eight years without speaking. Then one night, everything changed.

CEFR Level B1

Book 2 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A semi-detached house in Bristol. Two halves of the same building.

Genre: Mystery / Neighbourhood Drama

Characters

- James — 50. Secondary school history teacher. Methodical, solitary by habit.
- Miriam — 47. His neighbour. A physiotherapist. Has lived next door for eight years.
- The wall — separating, but also connecting, everything.
- Danny — 19. Miriam's son. His absence is central to the story.

James had lived at number thirty-four for eleven years. In that time he had spoken to his next-door neighbour — Miriam, number thirty-six — perhaps forty times. Practical exchanges: a parcel left on the step, the recycling bin blown over in a storm, a question about the shared drain. He knew a great deal about her life, nonetheless. The wall between their houses was Victorian and substantial, but not as thick as the Victorians had imagined when they built it.

He knew she was a physiotherapist. He knew she had a son who had left for university two years ago. He knew she ran on Tuesday and Thursday mornings because he heard the front door at six fifteen.

The information he had gathered about Miriam was involuntary — the acoustic consequence of living close to another person.

He knew her alarm went off at six, that she listened to the radio while she had breakfast, that she had a phone call every Sunday morning that sometimes went on for an hour. He had heard her cry once — about three years ago, late on a Thursday night. He had lain awake for some time afterwards, not knowing what to do with what he had heard.

He had done nothing, which he had subsequently told himself was the correct and respectful response.

On a Friday evening in November, he heard three knocks on the connecting door.

There was a connecting door between their houses — a standard feature of Victorian semis, usually locked from both sides and used only in emergencies. James had not opened his side in eleven years.

He stared at it for a moment.

Then he opened it.

Miriam was standing in the doorway. She was wearing her coat, which suggested she had just come in. Her face had the particular quality of someone who had been keeping themselves together and was about to stop.

'I'm sorry to bother you,' she said. 'I didn't know who else—'

He was at university in Edinburgh — his second year. He had, up until eleven days ago, called every Sunday.

He had missed three Sundays. His phone went to voicemail. His flatmates had said, via email, that he had been coming and going but seemed fine. She had contacted the university wellbeing team, who had told her they had been in contact with him and that he was not in immediate danger.

'Not in immediate danger is not the same as fine,' Miriam said.

James agreed. He made tea.

she could think of — Danny's friends from school, his girlfriend who was no longer his girlfriend, his tutor.

The tutor had said that Danny had missed the last two seminars but had submitted his most recent essay, late but complete.

The girlfriend — Emma — had said that Danny had broken up with her six weeks ago, abruptly and by text, and that she was not going to help because she was still hurt.

'That was six weeks ago,' Miriam said. 'That might be when it started.'

She had also been to Edinburgh, five days ago. She had knocked on his flat door. He had answered it, told her he was fine, and asked her to go home.

secondary school teacher — he had spent thirty years learning to distinguish between the version of a problem a student presented and the problem itself.

He asked: 'What does Danny usually do when something is wrong?'

Miriam thought. 'He goes quiet. He was always like that, even as a child. He deals with things internally and only tells you afterwards.'

'Has he ever gone this quiet before?' 'Once. When his father left. He was twelve. It lasted about six weeks and then he just — came back.'

'So he has a precedent for this,' James said.

Miriam looked at him. 'You're very calm about this.' 'I teach teenagers for a living,' he said.

a text, not an email — a letter.

'His generation doesn't write letters,' Miriam said.

'His generation also doesn't read them as performance,' James said. 'A letter arrives as an object. It doesn't demand an immediate response. It says: I wrote this and posted it and now it's yours to read in your own time.'

Miriam considered this. 'What would I say?' 'What do you want him to know?' 'That I'm not angry. That I'm not going to make demands. That I just want—' She stopped.

'Write that,' James said. 'Exactly that.'

— he sat at the other end of the table and marked essays, which was what he had been doing before she knocked.

When she was finished, she read the final version aloud. It was two paragraphs. It said that she had been worried but that she understood he needed space. It said that she was not going to come to Edinburgh again unless he asked. It said she loved him.

'It's very short,' she said.

'Short is good,' James said. 'Short means you know what you want to say.'

James had not expected to be involved beyond that evening. But he found that the connecting door, having been opened once, had somehow remained available.

On Sunday, Miriam knocked again — not in distress, just to say that she had posted the letter and to thank him.

On Tuesday, she knocked to say that Danny had called.

The Other Side of the Wall



For years, James has listened to life on the other side of the wall.

The call had been brief — ten minutes — but he had called. He had received the letter and, he said, it had helped. He was going to see his GP. He would call again on Sunday.

'You were right about the letter,' Miriam said.

Over the following weeks, James discovered something unexpected: he was better at being a neighbour than he had thought.

Not in the intrusive way he had always feared — he was not in any danger of becoming someone who stopped by uninvited or rang the doorbell to chat.

But the connecting door was now opened, on average, twice a week. Sometimes Miriam had news about Danny. Sometimes she had a question about something practical. Once she brought a portion of curry she said she had made too much of.

He did not resist any of this. He had, he realised, been more solitary than was actually comfortable.

In December, Miriam asked him why he had become a history teacher.

It was the kind of question he normally deflected, having a standard answer prepared.

Instead, he said: 'Because I was not good at the present when I was young. History felt safer — it was already over, you couldn't be wrong about it, everything had already happened.'

'And now?' 'Now I think I was wrong about all of that. History is full of things that haven't finished happening. But I like the teaching.'

Miriam looked at him for a moment. 'That's the most I've heard you say at once.'

'The question was better than average,' he said.

Danny came home for Christmas.

James knew this because he had been told — Miriam had mentioned it through the connecting door — and also because he could hear, through the wall, the particular sound of a house that had a young person in it again.

The Other Side of the Wall



One late-night visit from Miriam changes everything between them.

More movement. A different energy.

On Christmas Eve, Miriam knocked and asked if he was doing anything the following day.

He had been going to spend Christmas alone with a large historical biography and a meal he had ordered from a local restaurant. He had considered this, on balance, adequate.

'Come for lunch,' she said. 'It's just us. Danny would like to meet you, apparently.'

Danny was thin and quieter than Miriam had implied, but present — there was the word, James thought: present in the way that people who have been elsewhere and come back are present.

He thanked James, over lunch, for the advice about the letter.

'It wasn't really advice,' James said. 'Your mother was going to write it anyway. I just suggested the format.'

'She said you were calm about it when she wasn't,' Danny said.

'I'm a teacher. I've had a lot of practice at being calm about other people's problems.'

'What do you do when it's your own?' Danny asked.

James thought about this. 'Mostly I read history,' he said.

'It doesn't actually help, but it gives the problem company.' actually aslında practice at... de pratik "Reading history gives the problem company." Danny asks the right question. James gives an honest answer.

He had, during the two weeks at home, started talking to a counsellor at the university — something he had been resisting for months.

'He said the letter made him feel like he had less to explain,' Miriam told James through the connecting door on the evening after Danny left.

'Less to explain?' 'Yes. He said it told him that I wasn't going to make it harder than it was. That I wasn't expecting a full account of everything he had been feeling.'

James thought about this. 'Letters are good at that,' he said. 'They commit to a position and leave the rest open.' In February, James found himself thinking about the wall. He had been aware of it his entire time in the house — the solid fact of another life being lived six inches from his own — but he had always thought of it as a boundary.

He now thought of it as something else.

Walls in Victorian semis were not built to be soundproof. They were built to be shared. The house had been designed as two halves of a whole, connected by a door that was meant to be used.

He had not opened that door for eleven years.

He had always described this as minding his own business. He was no longer sure that was accurate.

In April, the connecting door was opened, on average, three times a week.

James had not consciously decided this. It had happened the way most things that were actually good happened — gradually and without announcement.

He had begun to know things about Miriam that he had not known through the wall: that she had trained as a dancer before she had studied physiotherapy; that she had a complicated relationship with her sister in Newcastle; that she was funnier than he had expected.

He told her, in turn, things that he had not expected to tell anyone: that he had been engaged, briefly, in his thirties; that he regretted not having kept up his French; that he had been happier since November.

It was handwritten, on university paper, from Danny.

It said, in full:

Dear Mr. James, My mum told me you suggested she write me a letter rather than text or call. I wanted to tell you that it was the right call. A letter can't be panicked. A text is always happening now. A letter has already happened. It arrived as a thing that was complete. Thank you for thinking of that.

The Other Side of the Wall



At the kitchen table, two neighbours turn silence into trust.

Danny.

James read it twice. He had not expected to be moved by a thank-you note from a nineteen-year-old.

He put it on the mantelpiece. It stayed there.

One evening in June, Miriam asked: 'Why did you open the door in November? You hadn't in eleven years.'

James thought about this properly.

'Because three knocks on a locked door means something different from a doorbell,' he said. 'A doorbell is a general enquiry. Three knocks on a connecting door means you've thought about it first.'

'I had thought about it,' Miriam said. 'I'd stood on my side for about five minutes.'

'I know,' James said. 'I could hear you.'

Miriam looked at him. 'The wall is quite thin,' she said.

'Yes,' he said. 'It always has been.'

In November, exactly one year after the three knocks, James sat in his kitchen and thought about the year.

Danny was in his third year at university. He called his mother on Sundays — not always, but often. He had called James twice, for no particular reason, which James had found unexpectedly pleasant.

He had been to Miriam's for dinner seven times. She had been to his for dinner three times.

He had opened the connecting door more than he could count.

He thought: I have been living next to a person for eleven years. This is what I know about her now. The before and the after were almost incomprehensible in their difference. The connecting door was now almost always unlocked on both sides.

This had not been discussed — it had simply happened.

On his side, James kept a key on the hook beside it, though he no longer needed it.

He had heard her cry once, three years ago, and had done nothing, which he had told himself was respectful.

He knew now that he had been wrong — not wrong to respect her privacy, but wrong about what privacy meant. Privacy was not the same as abandonment. A wall was not the same as a door.

He had spent eleven years confusing the two.

He was glad he had been wrong. It was, on balance, the best mistake he had made.

privacy mahremiyet "Privacy is not the same as abandonment." The best mistake he had made.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story so the reading pages remain in a natural storybook format.

1. semi-detached	yarı müstakil
2. recycling bin	geri dönüşüm kutusu
3. substantial	sağlam, kalın
4. nonetheless	yine de, bununla birlikte
5. parcel	paket
6. shared drain	ortak kanalizasyon
7. involuntary	istemsiz
8. acoustic consequence	akustik sonuç
9. subsequently	sonradan
10. respectful response	saygılı tepki
11. lain awake	uyanık yatmak
12. gathered	toplamış
13. connecting door	bağlantı kapısı
14. semis	yarı müstakil evler
15. emergencies	acil durumlar
16. keeping themselves together	kendini tutmak
17. quality	özellik, nitelik
18. bother	rahatsız etmek
19. up until	... a kadar
20. voicemail	sesli mesaj
21. wellbeing team	psikolojik destek ekibi
22. immediate danger	acil tehlike
23. flatmates	ev arkadaşları
24. coming and going	gelip gidiyor
25. idle	boş durmak
26. abruptly	aniden, birdenbire
27. seminar	seminer
28. submitted	teslim etti
29. tutor	akademik danışman
30. broke up with	ile ayrılmak
31. distinguish	ayırt etmek
32. internally	içsel olarak
33. precedent	emsal, önceki örnek
34. deals with	... ile başa çıkmak
35. presented	sunulan
36. calm	sakin
37. performance	performans (sosyal baskı anlamında)
38. demands an immediate response	hemen yanıt istemek

39. generation	nesil
40. make demands	taleplerde bulunmak
41. object	nesne, fiziksel şey
42. considered	düşündü
43. draft	taslak
44. marked essays	ödevleri düzeltti
45. read aloud	sesli okudu
46. space	alan, mesafe
47. version	versiyon, sürüm
48. finished	bitirdi
49. remained available	erişilebilir kalmak
50. distress	sıkıntı, çaresizlik
51. brief	kısa
52. GP	aile hekimi
53. posted	postaladı
54. somehow	bir şekilde
55. intrusive	müdahaleci, taciz eden
56. uninvited	davet edilmeden
57. on average	ortalama olarak
58. solitary	yalnız başına
59. resist	direnmek
60. portion	porsiyon
61. deflected	savuşturdu, önledi
62. standard answer	standart yanıt
63. safer	daha güvenli
64. full of things	şeylerle dolu
65. haven't finished happening	olmaya devam ediyor
66. energy	enerji
67. on balance	genel değerlendirmede
68. adequate	yeterli
69. biography	biyografi
70. apparently	görünüşe göre
71. ordered from	... dan sipariş etmek
72. implied	ima etmiş
73. format	biçim
74. elsewhere	başka yerde
75. gave the problem company	sorunu yalnız bırakmamak
76. counsellor	danışman, psikolog

77. resisting	direnmek
78. full account	tam açıklama
79. commit to a position	bir duruş sergilemek
80. leave the rest open	geri kalanı açık bırakmak
81. made it harder	daha zor hale getirmek
82. boundary	sınır
83. soundproof	ses geçirmez
84. minding his own business	kendi işiyle ilgilenmek
85. solid fact	somut gerçek
86. six inches	on beş santimetre
87. designed as	... olarak tasarlanmış
88. consciously	bilinçli olarak
89. gradually	yavaş yavaş
90. announcement	duyuru
91. engaged	nişanlı
92. regretted	pişman oldu
93. kept up	devam ettirmek
94. handwritten	el yazısıyla
95. panicked	paniklenmiş
96. in full	tümüyle, eksiksiz
97. complete	tamamlanmış
98. the right call	doğru karar
99. mantelpiece	şömine rafı
100. enquiry	sorgulama, başvuru
101. properly	düzgünce, gerçekten
102. thin wall	ince duvar
103. general enquiry	genel soru
104. thought about it first	önce düşündü
105. unexpectedly	beklenmedik şekilde
106. incomprehensible	kavranılmaz, akıl almaz
107. no particular reason	özel bir neden olmadan
108. pleasant	hoş
109. the before and the after	öncesi ve sonrası
110. could count	sayabilirdi
111. abandonment	terk etmek, ilgisizlik
112. confusing the two	ikisini birbirine karıştırmak
113. simply happened	sadece oldu
114. unlocked	kilitli

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word or phrase with the correct meaning.

Word / phrase

Meaning

1. substantial

A. müdahaleci

2. intrusive

B. sağlam, kalın

3. involuntary

C. istemsiz

4. precedent

D. emsal

5. deflected

E. savuşturdu

6. abandonment

F. terk etmek

7. adequate

G. yeterli

8. boundary

H. sınır

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word or phrase from the box.

letter — thin — solitary — available — panicked — precedent

1. James suggested Miriam write a _____ rather than a text or email.

2. Danny said a letter can't be _____ — it has already happened.

3. Once the connecting door had been opened, it somehow remained _____.

4. James realised he had been more _____ than was actually comfortable.

5. Danny had gone quiet before when his father left — he had a _____ for this.

6. James knew the wall was _____, but had treated it as a boundary for eleven years.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. James and Miriam had spoken frequently over the years.

—

2. Miriam's son Danny had stopped calling without explanation. ____

3. James suggests that Miriam should go to Edinburgh again.

—

4. Danny receives the letter and immediately comes home.

—

5. James spends Christmas alone that year. ____

6. At the end, the connecting door is unlocked on both sides.

—

Short Answer Questions

7. How does James know so much about Miriam's life despite rarely speaking?

8. What makes James's suggestion of a letter better than a text or call?

9. What does Danny's history with his father's departure tell James?

10. What does James realise about his own solitude during the story?

11. What does Danny write in his letter to James?

12. How does James explain why he opened the door in November?

13. What does the phrase 'privacy is not the same as abandonment' mean in context?

14. How does James describe reading history as a coping mechanism?

15. What is 'the best mistake' James refers to at the end?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-C 4-D 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. letter 2. panicked 3. available 4. solitary 5. precedent 6. thin

True / False: 1. F 2. T 3. F 4. F 5. F 6. T

7. The wall between Victorian semi-detached houses is thin — he hears her routines through it involuntarily.

8. A letter is an object that arrives complete — it doesn't demand an immediate response and can be read in the recipient's own time without pressure.

9. Danny has a precedent for going quiet — he did the same for six weeks when his father left, and eventually came back on his own.

10. He realises he had been more solitary than was actually comfortable — the wall had been a choice, not a necessity.

11. He thanks James for suggesting the letter format, saying a letter can't be panicked and arrived as something already complete.

12. Because three knocks on a connecting door means you've thought about it first — it is different from a doorbell, which is a general enquiry.

13. He had been treating silence as respect for Miriam's privacy, but had actually been abandoning her — privacy doesn't mean ignoring someone in need.

14. It doesn't help, but it gives the problem company — it provides a kind of companionship for the difficulty.

15. His eleven years of treating the wall as a barrier rather than a connection — being wrong about this led to opening the door.